

Topic Input: Gender

In this week we will look at the issue of gender norms, roles & stereotypes within the context of feminism & gender equality.

Gender Equality

Task 1: Discuss the following in pairs/small groups:

- What do you understand by the term 'gender equality'?
- What do you understand by the word 'Feminism'? Is it the same?
- Would you describe yourself as a 'Feminist'? Why/why not?
- Which factors do you think would influence whether or not someone **would** identify as feminist?
- Are you aware of any examples of mainstream feminism/gender equality in your country, or the world in general?

Task 2: Below is an article about why 'feminism' doesn't seem to be a popular term.

We are going to read actively – this means you should not only take notes, but also try to note down questions of the text. This is good practise for your Academic Interaction class.

e.g. Line one says “In recent years, feminist movements have attracted significant attention in Europe and North America”. A relevant question to note would be “what about other continents/countries?”

Text 1: Scharff, C. (2019) Why so many young women don't call themselves feminist. *BBC* [online]. Available from: <https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/uk-politics-47006912> [Accessed: 26 March 2020]

Why so many young women don't call themselves feminist

By Dr Christina Scharff, King's College London
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In recent years, feminist movements have attracted significant attention in Europe and North America. So why do so many young women still say they do not identify with the term? Fewer than one in five young women would call themselves a feminist, polling in the UK and US suggests.

That might come as a surprise as feminism - the advocacy of women's rights on the grounds of equality of the sexes - has been in the spotlight lately. A day after the inauguration of US President Donald Trump, millions around the world joined the 2017 Women's March. A key aim was to **highlight women's rights**, which many believed to be under threat. Another defining moment came when sexual harassment claims were made against film producer Harvey Weinstein by more than 80 women - **allegations he denies**.

Online movements have also gained momentum. Actress Alyssa Milano suggested that anyone who had been "sexually harassed or assaulted" should reply to her Tweet with "#MeToo", resurrecting a movement started by activist Tarana Burke in 2006. Half a million **responded in the first 24 hours** and the hashtag has been used in more than 80 countries.

Many other celebrities have publicly embraced feminism, including actresses Emma Watson, who **launched an equality campaign with the United Nations** and "body positivity warrior" Jameela Jamil. Movements like #everydaysexism and discussion points such as author Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie's Ted talk, **We should all be feminists**, have also struck a chord with millions.

Rejection of feminism

These events have all helped to bring feminism to mainstream attention. So it is perhaps unexpected that the identity "feminist" has not gained more popularity among young women in the Western world. In the UK there has been a small increase in the number of women who identify as such. A 2018 YouGov poll found that 34% of women in the UK said "yes" **when asked whether they were a feminist**, up from 27% **in 2013**. It's a similar picture in Europe, with fewer than half of men and women polled **in five countries** agreeing they were a feminist. This ranged from 8% of respondents in Germany, to 40% in Sweden.

However, people do not appear to reject the term feminism because they are against gender equality or believe it has been achieved. The same study found that eight out of 10 people said men and women **should be treated equally in every way**, with many agreeing sexism is still an issue.

This appears to represent a shift in attitudes over time. A study of 27,000 people in the US found that two-thirds **believed in gender equality** in 2016, up from a quarter in 1977. And in a 2017 UK poll, 8% said they **agreed with traditional gender roles** - that a man should earn money and a woman should stay at home - down from 43% in 1984.

If many believe gender equality is important, and still lacking, then why do relatively few people - including young women - identify as feminist? It could be that they do not feel the term speaks to them. The term feminist is less likely to appeal to working-class women, polls suggest.

What does it mean to be a feminist?

Almost one in three people from the top social grade ABC1 - those in managerial, administrative and professional occupations - **called themselves a feminist in a 2018 poll**. This compared with one in five from grades C2DE, which include manual workers, state pensioners, casual workers, and the unemployed. But those from lower income backgrounds are just as likely to support equal rights. Eight out of 10 people from both groups agreed men and women should be equal in every way, when asked for a **2015 poll**.

This may suggest lower income groups support the principle behind feminism, but aren't keen on the word itself.

Race can also shape views of feminism. Research into the views of **US millennials** found 12% of Hispanic women, 21% of African American women, 23% of Asian women and 26% of white women identify as a feminist. Three-quarters of all the women polled said the feminist movement has done either "a lot" or "some" to improve the lives of white women. However, just 60% said it had achieved much for women of other ethnicities - a sentiment shared by 46% of African American women.

Battling stereotypes

Another hurdle may be some of the stereotypes and misconceptions associated with feminism. In her introduction to the recently published anthology *Feminists Don't Wear Pink and Other Lies*, curator Scarlett Curtis refers to the stereotype of feminists as not wearing make-up, or shaving their legs or liking boys. These stereotypes have persisted through the ages. In the 1920s, feminists were often called spinsters and speculation about their sexual preferences was rife. Almost a century later, these views still hold some sway.

Having interviewed a diverse group of young German and British women **for my research**, I found associations of the term "feminism" with man-hating, lesbianism or lack of femininity was a key factor in rejections of the label "feminist". The majority said they did not want to call themselves feminist because they feared they would be associated with these traits. This was despite many stressing they were not homophobic and some identifying as lesbian or bisexual.

So, how could the image of feminism be improved? Arguably, as a society we should do more to challenge narrowly defined expectations of how women should look and act.

Working harder to make this movement more inclusive could mean that feminism speaks to the experiences and concerns of diverse groups of women. Nevertheless, whichever label women choose to adopt, the indication that the vast majority of people now support equality - and acknowledge it has not yet been achieved - is heartening.

About this piece

This analysis piece was **commissioned by the BBC from an expert working for an outside organisation.**

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Task 3: Compare your notes and your questions with your classmates. Your teacher will ask you to share some ideas you had.

Task 4: Try to come up with some explanations/ideas regarding the following; at this stage, we don't need definite answers, but it's important to explore the questions that have been raised:

P. 5: "A 2018 YouGov poll found that 34% of women in the UK said "yes" **when asked whether they were a feminist**, up from 27% **in 2013**. It's a similar picture in Europe, with fewer than half of men and women polled **in five countries** agreeing they were a feminist. This ranged from 8% of respondents in Germany, to 40% in Sweden."

◆ **UK: 27%, Germany: 8%, Sweden: 40% - why could it be so varied?**

P. 7: "And in a 2017 UK poll, 8% said they **agreed with traditional gender roles** - that a man should earn money and a woman should stay at home - down from 43% in 1984."

◆ **What do you think has caused the change of opinion over the last 30 years?**

P. 8 & 10: "It could be that they [people] do not feel the term speaks to them. The term feminist is less likely to appeal to working-class women, polls suggest... lower income groups support the principle behind feminism, but aren't keen on the word itself."

P. 9: “Almost one in three ...[of]...those in managerial, administrative and professional occupations **called themselves a feminist in a 2018 poll**. This compared with one in five from grades C2DE...manual workers, state pensioners, casual workers, and the unemployed. But those from lower income backgrounds are just as likely to support equal rights.”

◆ ***What do you think is the link between success/income/class and feminism?***

P. 13: “I found associations of the term "feminism" with man-hating, lesbianism or lack of femininity was a key factor in rejections of the label "feminist". The majority said they did not want to call themselves feminist because they feared they would be associated with these traits.”

◆ ***Are these stereotypes the same in your country?***

◆ ***How do you think these started? Who was responsible?***

P. 14 & 15: “...[H]ow could the image of feminism be improved? Arguably, as a society we should do more to challenge narrowly defined expectations of how women should look and act. Working harder to make this movement more inclusive could mean that feminism speaks to the experiences and concerns of diverse groups of women.”

◆ ***What do you think some worthy goals of modern-day feminists could be?***

P. 3 & 4: “Half a million **responded in the first 24 hours** and the hashtag has been used in more than 80 countries...Many other celebrities have publicly embraced feminism...”

◆ ***Is the link between success and Feminism exemplified with celebrities?***

◆ ***How helpful is celebrity endorsement? Do they mean it, or are they just self-promoting?***

P. 11: “[In the USA] 12% of Hispanic women, 21% of African American women, 23% of Asian women and 26% of white women identify as a feminist. Three-quarters of all the women polled said the feminist movement has done either "a lot" or "some" to improve the lives of white women. However, just 60% said it had achieved much for women of other ethnicities - a sentiment shared by 46% of African American women.”

◆ ***The respondents are different races, but the same nationality: can you think of reasons why feminism would only (seem) to support white women?***

◆ ***Why would the number of Hispanic women who identify as feminists be almost 50% lower than other groups?***

Gender Norms

Task 5: In small groups, discuss the following questions – if possible, try to work with some classmates from another country.

You could compare these to your parents' generation, but in your experience:

- What are some attributes expected of girls/women? And of boys/men?
- How are they expected to behave? What is encouraged, or avoided?
- How are they expected to look?
- What hobbies do they have (generally speaking)?
- Who is more likely to take on the role of managing the family and/or the home?
- What toys do young girls and boys play with?
- If you go out on a date with someone, who pays?

Task 6: Watch this brief 2018 video of some American children talking about gender stereotypes. Are they in agreement with what you've just discussed?

Boys and Girls

ON STEREOTYPES

Task 6: Gender norms, how men and women are 'expected to behave', are instilled at a very young age and can have profound consequences. How do you think they affect:

- Men and women's attitudes and behaviour
- Mental health
- Society
- Gender equality